

cloak\dagger\system>
cloak\dagger\system>more README.txt

##

In 2046, wealth and technology are used not for the common good but to strengthen the owners of capital and the armed bodies that protect them.

On the one hand the rich have more institutional influence than ever before: they whisper into the politicians' ears, and immediately new limitations are imposed on the freedom of movement, the freedom of assembly, and the right to privacy. Pretexts vary: domestic security; militarization; protectionist or anti-migrant bullsh*t; even --- most tragically --- environmental concerns. These measures only ever seem to affect workers and the poor: the rich are free to traverse the skies and the oceans on their jets and cruises.

On the other hand, the authorities have mastered the use of AI-assisted surveillance systems, spy-drones, and psychological warfare in order to combat dissent. At this point, everyone who's not a part of the ruling class believes some kind of revolution is needed; these repressive tools are the only things keeping the people from tearing the whole [system] down.

There are a few factions that wish to facilitate a revolution, though none are flawless in praxis or in morals. One such organization is [cloak\dagger] --- a coalition of hackers and self-trained soldiers that has managed to gather members internationally while remaining only a myth --- or a boogeyman --- to government agencies.

That's you, and you're about to enact your riskiest plan yet. Don't get caught before you're ready for a showdown.

##

This game is Human-made without AI. It is intended for solo play. It was developed for the "Game Jam 3000" hosted by the "Rules As Written" Discord community, a space dedicated to TTRPG design discussion.

DISCLAIMER: this game is ideological, but do not assume every aspect of [cloak\dagger]'s ideology matches the author's. It's also not a good game... it's a design experiment.

cloak\dagger\system>more RULES.txt

CH.1 -

```
#####  ##      ## ##### #####  ##      ## ##### #####  ##      ##  ##
##      ## ##      ##  ##      ##      ##  ##      ##  ##  ##  ##  ##  ##
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#####      ##      #####  ##      ##      ##      #####  ##      ##  ##
```

Here's a summary of the game's structure and rules:

The game itself can be divided into three parts. 1) Setup; 2) Tactical Mode; and 3) Chronicle Mode (which includes Scenes, Reports, and the Epilogue).

Here's a summary of what you'll find in the next chapters:

"CH.2 - READING A UUID:" contains instructions on how to interpret a Version 4 UUID for the purposes of this game. In short: you read them from left to right and burn a few alphanumerical characters each time you pursue one of your objectives.

"CH.3 - VARIABLES:" explains what variables are. In short: it's your stats + the timer for the defeat condition.

"CH.4 - SETUP:" contains the procedure used for determining your variables for the Tactical Mode of play; plus the procedure used for creating setting details and personages for the Chronicle Mode of play.

"CH.5 - OBJECTIVES:" contains information on the Tactical Mode of the game. In short: each turn you do a MOVE to advance one of your objectives; you complete BASIC OBJECTIVES to gain advantages and to unlock the MAJOR OBJECTIVES; and you complete MAJOR OBJECTIVES to win.

"CH.6 - CHRONICLE:" contains information on the Chronicle Mode of the game.

Read each chapter in order and you'll get it. Just know that some chapters use formulas like [variable = n], [variable += n], and [variable -= n]. Those simply mean "set the value of the specified variable to number", "raise the value of the specified variable by number", and "lower the value of the specified variable by number" respectively. For example, [cloak += 1] means "raise cloak by 1".

CH.2 -

```
##### #####      #####      #####  ##      ##      #####      #####      ##      ##  ##
##      ## ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
##### #####      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
##      ##      ##### #####  ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
##      ## #####  ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
```

The game utilizes a Version 4 UUID generator as the basis of its engine. You'll find websites hosting such generators by searching "UUID v4 generator" on any browser. Each time you need to generate a new UUID, click the [Generate] or [Refresh] button --- there's usually one --- or reload the page. You'll also need a virtual document or a piece of paper to write down your variables, the UUIDs you generate, and strike through "burned" (used) characters.

Here are four examples of Version 4 UUIDs. Let's learn how to read them for the purposes of this game.

- | | |
|---|---|
| 1) ba7e2ade-3b97-43e9-9798-784c79af904f | 3) 3678185e-29c3-472a-bdd2-b299425f29c7 |
| 2) 57a77fac-876e-409a-9d98-a73a0a1a86dc | 4) 5ecd4ba6-4afe-4f57-9631-7e1b4f25a3d6 |

- Notice that each UUID is composed of five blocks named "fields" of length 8, 4, 4, 4, and 12, separated by dashes.
- Notice that each UUID is unique, except for the number at the start of the 3rd field, which is always a 4 (for Version 4).
- Notice that UUIDs only contain letters from "a" to "f".

First off, read from left to right. You must burn characters on the left before accessing those on the right. It's kind of like a deck of cards: you must draw the cards at the top of the deck before getting to the ones at the bottom.

Dashes are ignored; alphanumeric characters are resources. You will burn them each time you make a MOVE to advance your objectives.

Numbers are read as they are and added together to reach a TOTAL.

When you get to a letter you must either stop there or burn it to proceed. Each letter has a special effect. Sometimes burning a letter is plainly beneficial --- other times you may want to save the benefit for your next MOVE, or postpone any undesired effects.

The number of characters you can read and burn at any given time depends primarily on the variable you're using to pursue your current objective.

Here's a legend for quick reference, with a description of the effects of each letter:

- 0-9 = add this number to the TOTAL.
- a = "amplify" = amplify this MOVE --- if successful, check two boxes instead of one.
- b = "burn" = You may burn a number of additional characters equal to the value of the variable you're using to perform this MOVE.
- c = "chronicle" = resolve the MOVE; then enter the Chronicle Mode for a Scene.
- d = "double" = double one of the numbers you're burning as a part of this MOVE. Can't be applied to the same numerical character twice in one MOVE.
- e = "extract" = you may create a copy of one unburned character from this UUID (= note it somewhere); you may burn it later at any point. You can never store more than 1 copy like this.
- f = "fours" = burn every remaining "4" in your UUID and add it to the TOTAL --- or, if no "4"s remain, subtract 4 from the TOTAL.

(That's "amplify - burn - chronicle - double - extract - fours". It's supposed to be mnemonic.)

WARNING 1: Two of these letters additionally do [risk += 1] when burned (see Setup Q3). Burning multiple means raising risk by multiple points in one go.

WARNING 2: After striking through every character in a UUID, end your MOVE early if necessary; next generate a new UUID and write it down; then [risk += 1].

...Speaking of which...

CH.3 -

```
##      ##      #####      #####      ##      ##      #####      #####      ##
##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
##      ##      ##      ##      #####      ##      ##      ##      #####      ##      #####      #####
##      ##      #####      ##      ##      ##      #####      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      #####      #####      #####      #####      ##
```

There are 4 variables you need to keep track of:

- [cloak] represents your skill in breaking down the cyber-defenses of the [system] and in keeping yours running; it's the strength of your hacker division.
- [dagger] represents your skill in real-world actions such as infiltration, observation, and, as a last resort, violence; it's the strength of your paramilitary division.
- [risk] represents how big the risks you're taking in pursuit of your objectives are. Inevitably, this will grow as the game goes on, but if it grows too quickly the authorities will catch up to you, and then... everything will have been for nothing. If [risk] reaches 16, ITS VALUE CAN NO LONGER BE MODIFIED. At the start of each subsequent turn do [opsec -= 1], and either [cloak -= 1] or [dagger -= 1].
- [opsec] stands for operative security. It always starts at 4 and can never be higher. IF [opsec] REACHES 0, YOU LOSE. ENTER CHRONICLE MODE FOR THE EPILOGUE.

You will use either [cloak] or [dagger] when making MOVES to pursue your objectives.

Aside from [opsec], the variables start at different numeric values depending on the choices you make during setup.

CH.4 -

```
#####      #####      #####      ##      ##      #####      ##
##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
#####      #####      ##      ##      ##      #####
      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##      ##
#####      #####      ##      #####      ##      ##
```

Most people have never heard of the [cloak\dagger] group. Most people who have, dismiss it as an urban legend. Most people who believe it exists, don't know much about how its members operate and think --- they only know rumors and stereotypes.

As the player, you have the liberty of defining some truths about [cloak\dagger]. Start by answering these questions; then feel free to fill in the blanks.

WARNING: these answers cannot be changed later.

Q1 - HOW IMPORTANT OF A FACTOR IS [cloak\dagger]'S PARAMILITARY WING?

Aside from hackers, [cloak\dagger]'s membership includes footsoldiers and investigators who share the same ultimate goal as their comrades who sit behind computer screens. But how large and influential is it?

- OPTION 1: IT'S OF SECONDARY IMPORTANCE. [cloak = 3] [dagger = 2] [risk = 0].
- OPTION 2: IT'S AN EQUAL PART OF THE GROUP. [cloak = 3] [dagger = 3] [risk = 2]
- OPTION 3: IT'S PREPONDERANT --- AND ROWDY AT TIMES. [cloak = 3] [dagger = 4] [risk = 4].

Q2 - WHAT DOES [cloak\dagger]'S INTERNAL STRUCTURE LOOK LIKE?

[cloak\dagger] is no book club. It's an international conspiracy. How does it remain active, synchronized, and hidden?

- OPTION 1: MAXIMUM UNITY OF ACTION --- WE'RE A CENTRALIZED VANGUARD ORGANIZATION. Start with 2 boxes checked in the "Refine the plan" BASIC OBJECTIVE.
- OPTION 2: OUR DIFFERENCES MAKE US STRONGER --- WE'RE AN ALLIANCE OF LOCAL GROUPS. Start with 1 box checked in the "POPULAR DEFENSE GROUPS" MAJOR OBJECTIVE. [risk += 1]
- OPTION 3: NO GODS, NO MASTERS --- WE'RE A FEDERATION OF FREE INDIVIDUALS. Start with 1 box checked in the "Cover your tracks" BASIC OBJECTIVE.

Q3 - WHAT'S [cloak\dagger]'S MORTAL FLAW?

Come on now. Everyone has flaws.

- OPTION 1: ARE WE SURE WE'RE READY FOR THIS? --- HESITANCY. When burning the letter "a" or "b", [risk += 1].
- OPTION 2: IF NOT WE, THEN WHO? --- MESSIANIC EGOMANIA. When burning the letter "c" or "d", [risk += 1].
- OPTION 3: TRUST NO ONE --- PARANOIA. When burning the letter "e" or "f", [risk += 1].

Remember to write down the variables you've just defined. Also write down which letters raise [risk] for you when activated.

Next you'll need to define some truths about the setting.

For example, what's the dominant power in the world in 2046? China and the USA are safe bets; but you can go more speculative and decide that a third power rose to prominence in the aftermath of a Sino-American war; like a unified Europe or an ultramodern India. Don't get nationalistic: a superpower is just the system's most loyal servant. This question's here to help you decide where the bulk of the action should be set... though maybe you would prefer [cloak\dagger]'s attacks to happen simultaneously across different continents.

Next, what's the geopolitical trend? Is the world on the path to confederalizing under one law, in the name of stability and free trade? Maybe it's just the opposite: nations are being carved up into small fiefs managed by wealthy individuals. Or it could be neither: national borders have served capitalism well, and they shall be maintained, as they allow the system to

benefit from conflicts and prejudices. Regardless of what you choose, the world doesn't have to look too different from what we all know: reforming the world order is a long process.

Then, what's the favored political mask for the system? In 2046 popular will means almost nothing, but officially most countries might still uphold a superficial democracy. Alternatively, they may have turned into enlightened technocracies, paying lip service to rational and progressive ideals while still sowing destruction and inequality. Or just make the bad guys full on fascists; I know you want to, and that's okay.

Lastly you'll need to create 3 to 6 fictional people who live in this world and who will act as POV characters in your Chronicle. These are called personages, in order to avoid confusion with alphanumeric "characters".

Each can be a member of [cloak\dagger]; a powerful individual or an agent of the system; or a civilian who will either witness the effects of the two factions' conflict from the sidelines, or attempt to join one of the two sides.

Other than that, each personage needs a nationality, a name, an age, a mood, and a motivation. Not much else. Write down these details in the same place where you keep your variables and UUIDs.

Good motivations for [cloak\dagger]-aligned personages include a simple desire for greater personal freedom; a strong sense of justice mixed with terrible pride and boredom; or grief for a loved one who was killed by law enforcement or by poverty.

Good motivations for system-aligned personages include greed; a desire to protect one's family above all else; a strong belief in social stability or control; or even a disaffected "just following orders" attitude.

Neutral personages could pull motivations from either of the previous lists; have a strong ideological stance against both sides; or be too exhausted from work and hardship to fight.

CH.5 -

#####	#####	##	#####	#####	#####	####	##	##	#####	#####	##
##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##
##	##	#####	##	#####	##	##	##	##	#####	#####	
##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##
#####	#####	#####	#####	#####	##	####	###	#####	#####	##	

After setup, you will enter Tactical Mode, which functions as a sequence of turns. On each turn select an objective to advance; then make a MOVE:

Check the variable the objective specifies, and read an amount of unburned characters equal to its value; then burn the numbers from left to right and add them to your MOVE's TOTAL. When you reach a letter you can either stop reading or burn the letter, activating its effects. Remember to strike through each character you burn.

- The MOVE is a SUCCESS if the TOTAL is 16 or more. Check 1 objective box.
- The MOVE is a FAILURE if the TOTAL is 15 or less. [risk += 1]

A MOVE's TOTAL does not carry over to the next turn in any way.

When all of an objective's boxes are checked, it's completed, and its effects activate. ENTER CHRONICLE MODE FOR A REPORT.

BASIC OBJECTIVES # always available

[_][_][_] Refine the plan --- use [cloak] or [dagger] --- effect: [cloak += 1] [dagger += 1]
[_][_][_] Smuggle in compromised hardware --- use [dagger] --- effect: [cloak += 1] [risk +=1]
[_][_][_] Microdrone-assisted scouting --- use [cloak] --- effect: [dagger += 1] [risk +=1]
[_][_][_] Cover your tracks --- use [dagger] --- effect: [risk -= 1]
[_][_][_] Secure zombie computers --- use [cloak] --- effect: [risk -= 1]
[_] Scorched earth cyber-tactics --- use [cloak] --- effect: [opsec += 1]; strike through the field that comes after the active field in your UUID, without getting any benefits from it.

MAJOR OBJECTIVES # available after completing 4 BASIC OBJECTIVES

[_][_][_] DISRUPT THE PANOPTICON --- use [cloak] --- effect: [opsec += 2] --- {We'll stun the camera networks and surveillance algorithms that fill every corner of the streets and of the internet. The people will take it upon themselves to rip their electronic guts out.}
[_][_][_] POPULAR DEFENSE GROUPS --- use [dagger] --- effect: [dagger += 1] --- {Some of our soldiers will begin forming small militias, pulling members from low income neighborhoods.}
[_] TELEVISE THE REVOLUTION --- use [cloak] or [dagger] --- effect: none --- {People are already using their newfound freedom the way we expected they would. We'll do what we can to keep their enthusiasm high and broadcast their deeds internationally.}

AFTER COMPLETING ALL MAJOR OBJECTIVES, YOU WIN. ENTER CHRONICLE MODE FOR THE EPILOGUE.

CH.6 -

#####	##	##	#####	#####	##	##	####	#####	##	#####	##
##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##
##	#####	#####	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	#####	
##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##	##
#####	##	##	##	#####	##	##	####	#####	#####	#####	##

Chronicle Mode consists in you writing down Scenes, Reports, and eventually the Epilogue. Their purpose is to make the game come alive through narrative. They can be of whatever length and quality you desire, as long as you're having fun.

-- Page 7 of 8 --

It's similar to what other solo TTRPGs call journaling, but with more structure.

You'll write a Scene each time you burn the letter "c" in a UUID. First finish your MOVE, then follow this procedure:

- 1) SCENES SHOULD FEEL PERSONAL AND CINEMATIC. Pick at least one personage through whose point of view you will describe the scene. The personage can be a bystander, someone actively working toward your objective, someone working against you, or some fourth thing.
- 2) Use the name of the MOVE you just made, its outcome, and the level of [risk] to come up with a focal point for the scene: an obstacle; something suspicious happening; a new personage, antagonistic to the first, appearing...
- 3) Describe the personages' actions and/or inner monologue.
- 4) If your MOVE was a SUCCESS, describe a resolution that favors your side: the operation goes smoothly, a new resource is acquired, anti-government protests grow, etc. Otherwise, describe a dangerous escalation, a retreat, an agent of the system gaining a better understanding of [cloak\dagger]'s plans, or whatever fits.

You'll write a Report each time you complete an objective.

- 1) REPORTS SHOULD FEEL OBJECTIVE AND BUREAUCRATIC. They're messages through which [cloak\dagger] keeps its members up-to-date on their operations.
- 2) If your MOVES in pursuit of this objective were all SUCCESSes, simply describe how the objective was accomplished and what advantage this brings to the group.
- 3) If any of your MOVES were FAILUREs, describe what went wrong and what this means for future operations.

You'll write an Epilogue after you win (complete all MAJOR OBJECTIVES) or lose (have [opsec] reach 0).

- If you win while [opsec] is 3 or more, THE EPILOGUE IS HOPEFUL, BUT MOST PEOPLE DON'T UNDERSTAND [cloak\dagger]'S ROLE AND LOOK FOR LEADERS ELSEWHERE. system
- If you win while [opsec] is 2 or less, MAKE THE EPILOGUE TRIUMPHANT, AND DESCRIBE [cloak\dagger] BECOMING THE SYMBOL OF THE REVOLUTION.
- If you lose, THE SYSTEM IS TEMPORARILY STRENGTHENED. [cloak\dagger]-aligned personages will face prison, death, or voluntary exile.
- In any case, describe the feelings and the fate of each personage.

That's the whole game. Thank you for reading.

```
cloak\dagger\system>
cloak\dagger\system>more CREDITS.txt
##### CREDITS: #####
#                               #
#  DESIGN: ruminastro.itch.io  #
#  ADVICE: fedmar.itch.io      #
#  FONT: Geist Mono             #
#                               #
#####
```